



Pics: FSDL/FOCUS SPORTS

High operational costs, poor gate revenue, and diminishing broadcast numbers mean clubs have struggled to make it a profitable venture.

stadium for free. That's a major chunk of operational cost gone. A lot of sponsors also came in through the government. That really helped the club manage their finances," another source added. "Also, manpower was reasonably cheaper than in Delhi because the cost of living in Odisha is lower."

Another founding club, Chennaiyin FC — a two-time champion — has consistently flirted with the idea of shifting base due to its bloated operational costs.

Hyderabad FC, which absorbed the operations of Pune City after a takeover, also inherited the financial muddle caused by the original franchise run by the Wadhawan Group.

The club had been in the red, and despite multiple efforts to bring in investors, it never managed to break even in six years of its existence — even after winning the title in 2022.

Issues lingering on from FC Pune City's holding company carried forward indirectly to HFC, and with the pandemic adding to the woes,

the club struggled to break out of those shackles, playing with a constantly increasing financial burden year-on-year.

By the time HFC's owners managed to figure out a solution — which included transferring franchise rights to a novated company — it was already knee-deep in losses. Without immediate financial injection, the club struggled to hold things together.

"There were players, coaches whose salaries got delayed for quite some time," a source said. "And after a point, players and staff started leaving, and the club was suffering from ballooning losses. The league should have acted earlier, but it seemed like they waited till the last minute to force the sale."

The franchise has now shifted base to Delhi under new owners Jindal Football, who bought the franchise rights in August 2024 under the ambit of the BC Jindal Group. Legacy club Mohammedan SC's participation in next season's competition is still up in the air — and

Fall of dominoes: Only five of the league's original eight franchises remain, as financial pressures toppled clubs one after another.

so is the fate of the league.

Entry of FSDL

The Master Rights Agreement (MRA), signed in 2010 by the All India Football Federation (AIFF) and its commercial partner Football Sports Development Limited (FSDL), will expire in December this year.

"When IMG Reliance entered into the partnership with AIFF, it wasn't just a financial transaction. It was a long-term commitment to revitalise Indian football. The objective was to bring in strong investors in the form of clubs and start a new league which can expand football's fanbase in India, while also providing AIFF financial stability to work on grassroots and accelerate development of footballers," a source told *Sportstar*.

"In 2010, Indian football's viewership had gone down to 15